

United States vs Australia Audit Parameter Norms

All 8 pillars, all 165 scored parameters. For every parameter: the norm the engine actually scores against, its weight, the US benchmark, the AU benchmark, and the exact change required.

SCOPE	MARKETS	VERIFIED AGAINST	VERTICAL	PREPARED
8 pillars · 165 parameters	US · AU	Backend/metricServices · live weights	Automotive retail	August 2026

How to read this document

Every parameter your engine returns is listed — including the ones weighted at zero. Each row carries five things.

Column	What it contains	Why it is there
Parameter	Display name, the exact key the engine returns, and its weight inside the pillar. info means weight 0 — returned and shown, but excluded from the pillar score.	So a finding in the PDF maps to one line of code, and so you can see how much a difference is actually worth.
Norm	The actual bar the engine scores against — real thresholds read out of the source, not generic advice. Where the engine grades on a curve, the full curve is given.	This is the part that was missing from v1. Without it you cannot tell whether a "difference" changes a number or only changes wording.
US / AU	What that norm resolves to in each market: the same number, a different reference list, or a different legal requirement.	Side-by-side so the answer to "what is different here" is one glance, not a paragraph.
Action	The concrete engineering change — or an explicit "no change".	Turns the comparison into a work list.

Difference types

LEGAL	A statute or regulator sets the bar. Different rule in each market.	CONVENTION	No law; buyer expectation and market practice differ.	DATA	Same rule, different reference list, provider or benchmark.
IDENTICAL	Same norm, same number, same score in both markets.				

Corrections applied in this version

- 1. Norm values added for every parameter.** v1 described differences without stating the benchmark being compared. Every threshold in this version was read out of `Backend/metricServices` — for example Title grades 45–65 chars = 1.0, 35–44 = 0.85, 25–34 = 0.70, <25 = 0.50, 66–75 = 0.80, >75 = 0.50; it is not a flat "50–60 chars" rule.
- 2. Parameter inventory corrected to 165.** v1 said "~150" and mis-assigned several checks. `Local_SEO`, `EEAT` and `Content_Freshness` are computed inside `seoMetrics.js` but are **deliberately hidden from the On-Page SEO return** (rule-4 de-duplication) because AEO and AIO already score them. They are documented under Pillar 5 / Pillar 6, where they are actually weighted — not under Pillar 1 as v1 showed them.
- 3. Weight-zero parameters flagged.** `Content_Relevance` is returned but carries **no weight** (hidden 2026-07-07 pending redesign). v1 called it "the highest-leverage content fix" — it currently moves the On-Page score by exactly zero. The AU vocabulary work is still worth doing, but its value lands in AEO and AIO, not here. Same applies to Accessibility's `Text_Spacing`, `Focus_Not_Obscured` and `Reduced_Motion`, which are informational manual-review checks.
- 4. Accessibility structure corrected.** The pillar weights 17 parameters in three severity tiers (Critical ×3, Serious ×2, Moderate ×1). `Focus_Order`, `Focusable_Content`, `Tab_Index` and `Aria_Hidden_Focus` are **sub-checks of** `Keyboard_Navigation`, not independently weighted parameters.

Not legal advice. Regulatory positions reflect mid-2026 and are here to tell you *what to look for on a page*. Privacy, credit and motor-dealer law move quickly and vary by US state and AU state/territory. Have customer-facing compliance wording reviewed by local counsel, and phrase every finding as an observation about the page ("no comparison rate is shown next to the advertised rate"), never as a legal conclusion.

Overview — where the differences actually are

Counts below are exact, taken from the live weight maps. "Weight at risk" is the share of a pillar's score controlled by parameters whose norm, reference list or applicability changes between markets.

Pillar	Params	Identical	Changed	Weight at risk	What drives the difference
1 • On-Page SEO	22	18	4	≈5%	Only <code>Title_Location_Optimization</code> (2%) and <code>Social_Links</code> (1%) carry weight. Structural SEO is fully global.
2 • Technical Performance	15	13	2	0%	Zero threshold changes. TTFB and <code>Redirect_Chains</code> need market-aware <i>interpretation</i> only — offshore hosting, RTT cost, CrUX data availability.
3 • Accessibility	26	25	1	≈9%	Only <code>Html_Has_Lang</code> (Critical, ×3) if you require the regional subtag. Legal citations change everywhere.
4 • Security & Compliance	25	18	7	≈26%	Transport and headers identical. Privacy, consent, finance-form and disclaimer rules are entirely different regimes.
5 • AEO	16	7	9	≈48%	Every entity, citation and credential reference list is American. Highest proportional exposure of any pillar.
6 • AIO Readiness	11	8	3	≈30%	Vehicle taxonomy and structured-data values. Parsing logic itself is market-neutral.
7 • UX & Content	17	13	4	≈31%	Expected navigation items, inventory facets and gallery shots. Readability needs only a relabel.
8 • Conversion & Lead Flow	33	17	16	≈55%	Pricing law, finance disclosure, vehicle history, valuation providers, trust badges, consent model.
Total	165	119	46	≈26% of all weight	72% of parameters need no market logic whatsoever. One engine + one locale pack + a small set of market-only checks.

The twelve changes that matter most, ranked by score impact

#	Parameter	Pillar	Weight	Why it is wrong today for AU	Fix
1	<code>TradeIn_Flow</code>	8	0.15	Detects KBB / Black Book / J.D. Power. Australia uses RedBook and Glass's Guide; neither is in the list, so a complete AU trade-in tool scores near zero.	Swap the valuation-provider dictionary.

#	Parameter	Pillar	Weight	Why it is wrong today for AU	Fix
2	Appointment_Booking	8	0.12	Booking UX is global, but AU needs a collection notice where licence/ID details are captured (APP 3 / APP 5), and state trading-hours rules differ.	Add AU collection-notice sub-check.
3	Financing_Flow	8	0.10	Looks for US credit-application patterns. AU requires an Australian Credit Licence number disclosed by the credit-assistance provider.	Add ACL-number check for AU.
4	Finance_Calculator	8	0.10	Checks for APR disclosure (Reg Z). AU instead requires a comparison rate plus the prescribed warning whenever a rate is advertised.	Swap the disclosure checklist per market.
5	Finance_Form_Security	4	0.10	Framed on the GLBA Safeguards Rule, which has no AU equivalent. AU basis is APP 11 plus NCCP conduct obligations.	Same DOM checks, market-specific authority and severity text.
6	EEAT_Composite	5	0.10	Credential dictionary is ASE / NADA / BBB. None exist in Australia; AU credibility is dealer licence number, ABN, AADA, VACC/MTA, RACV/NRMA/RACQ.	Swap the credential dictionary.
7	Legal_Disclaimers	4	0.08	Built on Reg Z / Reg M / FTC rules. AU runs on ACL s48 total pricing, consumer guarantees, comparison rate and dealer licence display.	Separate rule set per market — not a translation.
8	Citation_NAP_Consistency	5	0.06	Phone normaliser keeps the last 10 digits and the address parser is US-shaped. Both fail on AU data, producing false "no NAP detected".	Market-aware phone + address normalisers.
9	Pricing_Transparency	8	0.06	US model is MSRP plus disclosed fees. AU has a hard legal rule: total GST-inclusive price at least as prominent as any component (ACL s48).	Add AU drive-away/total-price prominence check.
10	Entity_Recognition	5	0.07	No AU entity anchor. The ABN is a public, resolvable government identifier — the strongest grounding signal an Australian business has.	Add ABN presence/consistency sub-signal.
11	FAQ_QA_Blocks	5	0.07	Expected-topic list is US: APR, CARFAX, doc fees. AU buyers ask about drive-away price, PPSR, roadworthy, statutory warranty, stamp duty.	Swap the expected-topic list.
12	Vehicle_History	8	0.04	Detects CARFAX / AutoCheck, which do not operate in Australia. The AU equivalent is a PPSR certificate.	Swap the history-provider dictionary.

Read the ranking this way: nine of the top twelve are **dictionary swaps** — a list of provider names, credentials or topics. Only three (Pricing_Transparency, Finance_Calculator, Legal_Disclaimers) need genuinely new detection logic. That is why this is a locale-pack problem, not an engine-fork problem.

Ten primitives that a third of the parameters depend on. Fix these once in a locale pack and most per-parameter differences resolve themselves.

Primitive	Norm in the engine today	United States	Australia	Parameters affected
Language tag	Accessibility requires a valid <code>lang</code> on <code><html></code> . Bare <code>en</code> currently passes.	CONVENTION <code>en-US</code> . Spelling: color, center, license, organization, tire, curb, catalog, analyze.	CONVENTION <code>en-AU</code> . Spelling: colour, centre, licence (noun), organisation, tyre, kerb, catalogue, analyse.	<code>Html_Has_Lang</code> , all keyword-matching content checks.
Currency	Schema <code>priceCurrency</code> validity; price presence on VDP/offer.	LEGAL USD. Displayed price conventionally excludes sales tax; tax varies by state and county.	LEGAL AUD. ACL s48 — total minimum price including 10% GST must be at least as prominent as any component.	<code>Pricing_Transparency</code> , <code>Incentives_Displayed</code> , <code>Finance_Calculator</code> , <code>Schema_Markup</code> , <code>Structured_Data</code> .
Address format	<code>tuParseUsAddress</code> — regex tuned to "City, ST 12345".	CONVENTION City + 2-letter state + 5-digit ZIP.	CONVENTION Suburb + state code (NSW VIC QLD WA SA TAS ACT NT) + 4-digit postcode.	<code>Citation_NAP_Consistency</code> , <code>Title_Location_Optimization</code> , <code>Topical_Authority</code> , local sub-checks.
Phone format	Normalises to the last 10 digits ; a number is "real" at ≥10 digits.	CONVENTION NANP 10 digits, <code>+1</code> , toll-free 800-series.	CONVENTION <code>+61</code> , 9 national digits. Landline <code>(07) 3000 1234</code> , mobile <code>04xx</code> , business <code>1300 / 1800</code> , and <code>13 xx xx</code> — only 6 digits .	Currently broken for AU. <code>Citation_NAP_Consistency</code> , <code>Click_To_Call</code> .
Distance & fuel units	Spec-field extraction on VDPs; schema unit codes.	LEGAL Miles (<code>SMI</code>), MPG, EPA/Monroney label.	LEGAL Kilometres (<code>KMT</code>), L/100km + CO ₂ g/km under ADR 81/02, Green Vehicle Guide label.	<code>VDP_Content_Uniqueness</code> , <code>Structured_Data</code> , <code>Terminology_Consistency</code> .
Date format	Freshness parser reads visible + schema dates.	CONVENTION MM/DD/YYYY visible; ISO 8601 machine.	CONVENTION DD/MM/YYYY visible; ISO 8601 machine.	<code>Content_Updated_Regularly</code> , form validation checks.
Trading hours	<code>openingHours</code> presence and validity.	CONVENTION ET/CT/MT/PT, DST nationwide bar two states, Sunday trading unrestricted.	CONVENTION AEST/ACST/AWST; QLD, WA and NT skip DST. Sunday and public-holiday trading vary by state; many yards close Sundays.	<code>Appointment_Booking</code> , local schema.
Domain / TLD	Used as a market and trust signal.	CONVENTION <code>.com</code> , no eligibility test.	LEGAL <code>.com.au</code> / <code>.au</code> restricted by auDA — requires ABN, ACN or an Australian trade mark.	Market detection, <code>Brand_Entity_Strength</code> , <code>Entity_Recognition</code> .

Primitive	Norm in the engine today	United States	Australia	Parameters affected
Business identifier	Not currently checked.	CONVENTION EIN/DUNS, rarely displayed. Dealer licence display varies by state.	LEGAL ABN publicly resolvable via ABN Lookup, conventionally in the footer. Dealer licence number required in advertising — VIC LMCT, NSW, QLD.	Two new AU parameters proposed; feeds <code>Entity_Recognition</code> , <code>Trust_Badges</code> , <code>EEAT_Composite</code> .
Automotive vocabulary	Keyword lists inside relevance, topical, terminology and CTA checks.	CONVENTION pickup, gas, trunk, hood, windshield, tire, license plate, MSRP, out-the-door, doc fee, lot, CARFAX.	CONVENTION ute, petrol, boot, bonnet, windscreen, tyre, rego, RRP, drive-away , on-road costs, car yard, roadworthy/RWC, PPSR, novated lease.	<code>Content_Relevance</code> , <code>Topical_Authority</code> , <code>Terminology_Consistency</code> , <code>Keywords_Entities_Annotated</code> , <code>CTA_Clarity</code> , <code>FAQ_QA_Blocks</code> .

03 Pillar 1 — On-Page SEO · 22 parameters · 18 identical · 4 changed · ≈5% of weight at risk

The most market-neutral of the content pillars. Google's crawler behaves identically in both countries, so every structural norm is a shared number. Only four parameters touch national reference data, and two of those carry no weight.

Parameter	Norm the engine scores against	US	AU	Action
Title Title 0.10	Graded length curve: 45–65 chars = 1.0 ; 35–44 = 0.85; 25–34 = 0.70; <25 = 0.50; 66–75 = 0.80; >75 = 0.50. Missing or empty = 0. Ignores <code><title></code> inside inline SVG.	IDENTICAL Same curve.	IDENTICAL Same curve. Only the words inside differ.	No change.
Title uniqueness Title_Uniqueness 0.03	Duplicate detection across a sampled set of eligible internal pages (sitemap + homepage links).	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change.
Title location optimisation Title_Location_Optimization 0.02	Binary: 100 or 0. Collects every geographic term the business itself declares (schema <code>PostalAddress</code> locality/region/country, geo meta tags, brand names) and checks whether the title contains one.	CONVENTION City + 2-letter state. Metro names accepted.	CONVENTION Suburb is the dominant unit; capital city and state codes secondary. A state code alone is a weak signal.	Change. Needs an AU suburb/locality gazetteer, and <code>addSplit</code> already handles AU-QLD — extend the same idea to bare suburb names.
Meta description Meta_Description 0.06	Graded length curve: 120–160 chars = 1.0 ; 90–119 = 0.90; 50–89 = 0.75; <50 = 0.50; 161–180 = 0.85; >180 = 0.60. Missing = 0.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change.
Meta description uniqueness Meta_Description_Uniqueness 0.03	Same sampled-page duplicate detection as titles.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change.
Canonical Canonical 0.11	Highest-weighted On-Page parameter. Exactly one <code>rel=canonical</code> , inside <code><head></code> , resolving to a normalised self URL = 1.0. Multiple canonicals, outside head, or absent = 0; mismatch = 0.5.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL One nuance: a group running <code>.com</code> and <code>.com.au</code> needs self-canonical per market plus hreflang, never cross-canonical.	No change.
H1 H1 0.07	Exactly one non-empty H1 = 1.0. Multiple H1s or an empty H1 = 0.5. No H1 = 0.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change.
Heading hierarchy Heading_Hierarchy 0.04	No skipped levels and a present H1 = 1.0. Any hierarchy issue = 0.5. No headings at all = 0.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change.

Parameter	Norm the engine scores against	US	AU	Action
Images Image 0.08	Weighted composite: meaningful alt text (≥ 2 words or > 5 chars, rejecting placeholder words), next-gen format (WebP/AVIF via <code><picture></code> or extension), lazy-loading ratio (exempt when ≤ 4 images), responsive <code>srcset</code> , descriptive filenames, and file weight.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL Alt text should carry AU vocabulary and AUD prices.	No change.
Links Links 0.07	No broken links and descriptive-anchor ratio $\geq 0.75 = 1.0$; otherwise 0.5. Absorbed the removed Contextual_Linking weight, so the internal-link group stays at 7%.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change.
Content relevance Content_Relevance info · 0	Compares body content against title, meta description and page type. Returned but weighted 0 — hidden 2026-07-07 pending redesign, and its card is hidden in the UI.	DATA US automotive corpus: MSRP, trade-in, APR, lease, CARFAX.	DATA AU corpus: drive-away, on-road costs, RWC, PPSR, rego, comparison rate, RedBook.	Change the vocabulary — but note it moves the score by zero today. The same word list pays off in AEO and AIO, which are weighted.
URL structure URL_Structure 0.05	Clean = 1.0. Issues graded by severity: low-severity only $\rightarrow 0.7$ (0.5 if ≥ 3); any high-severity $\rightarrow 0.5$ (0.3 if ≥ 2). High severity includes uppercase in the path; segments over 40 chars are flagged.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL Watch the 40-char segment rule against long AU place names (e.g. <code>/woolloomgabby-used-cars/</code>).	No change.
URL slugs URL_Slugs 0.03	Same severity grading. Penalises slugs that are $\geq 50\%$ numeric tokens, or where stop words exceed half the word count. Rewards keyword alignment with the page.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change; the place-name list applies if you assert "location in slug".
Robots.txt Robots_Txt 0.08	Present and fetchable, valid syntax, not blocking crawlable content; also feeds the sitemap discovery chain.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change.
Open Graph Open_Graph 0.03	Requires <code>og:title</code> , <code>og:image</code> and <code>og:url</code> .	IDENTICAL <code>og:locale = en_US</code> .	IDENTICAL <code>og:locale = en_AU</code> .	No change unless you start scoring <code>og:locale</code> .
Twitter Card Twitter_Card 0.02	Requires <code>twitter:card</code> and <code>twitter:title</code> .	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change.

Parameter	Norm the engine scores against	US	AU	Action
Social links Social_Links 0.01	Presence of links to recognised social profiles.	DATA Facebook, Instagram, YouTube, X, TikTok, LinkedIn, Yelp , GBP.	DATA Same global platforms; Yelp is irrelevant in AU . Locally meaningful: carsales.com.au dealer page, ProductReview.com.au, Autotrader.com.au, CarsGuide, Drive.	Change the profile list . Low weight here, but the same list drives AEO <code>SameAs_Validation</code> .
Semantic tags Semantic_Tags 0.05	Semantic-block to <code><div></code> ratio must clear 0.1 (below that = "div soup"); sections should carry headings or an accessible label. Raw score ≥ 0.9 rounds to 1.0 .	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change. W3C semantics, not a market convention.
Viewport Viewport 0.03	<code>width=device-width + initial-scale=1</code> = 1.0; device-width only = 0.85; no device-width = 0.5. Disabling pinch-zoom caps the score at 0.5 .	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change.
VDP content uniqueness VDP_Content_Uniqueness 0.12 · VDP	Page-type add-on. Jaccard fingerprint comparison of VDP copy against OEM boilerplate and sibling VDPs.	DATA Distinguishing fields: trim, MPG, miles, VIN, MSRP, packages, CARFAX summary.	DATA Distinguishing fields: variant/badge, L/100km, kilometres, VIN, build date vs compliance date , rego expiry, RWC status, drive-away price, PPSR status.	Change the extraction fields or AU VDPs read as thin. Build/compliance date has no US analogue.
SRP index control SRP_Index_Control 0.08 · SRP	Faceted-navigation index control: canonical handling, robots meta, parameter hygiene on search-results pages.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change.
SRP → VDP links SRP_To_VDP_Links 0.06 · SRP	Crawl depth from search-results pages into vehicle detail pages.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change.

Where Local SEO, E-E-A-T and Content Freshness went. Those checks still run inside `seoMetrics.js`, but the engine deliberately drops them from the On-Page SEO return so they are not double-counted — AEO already scores E-E-A-T and NAP, and AIO already scores freshness. Their US/AU differences are therefore documented in Pillars 5 and 6, where they carry weight.

Not one threshold changes between markets. Core Web Vitals numbers are Google constants, and the log-normal scoring curve is Lighthouse's. What differs is physics and data availability — an AU audience hitting a US origin pays a real latency penalty, and small AU sites more often have no field data.

Never invent AU-adjusted thresholds. If you relax LCP or TTFB for Australia, your scores stop matching PageSpeed Insights and Search Console — the two tools every customer will check you against. Market awareness belongs in the **diagnosis and recommendation**, never in the bar.

Parameter	Norm the engine scores against	US	AU	Action
PageSpeed score PageSpeed_Score	Lighthouse Performance category. Fallback re-weighting when PSI returns no category score: TBT 30, LCP 25, CLS 25, FCP 10, SI 10.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL Lab runs are throttled the same way regardless of origin location.	No change.
LCP LCP 22	Log-normal curve, good 2500 ms / poor 4000 ms. Field (CrUX p75) preferred over lab; weighted once, with <code>confidence</code> recording which was used.	IDENTICAL Domestic origins usually clear it on hosting alone.	IDENTICAL Same numbers — but LCP inherits TTFB, so a US-only origin drags AU field LCP for identical code.	Threshold unchanged. For AU, lead the recommendation with origin/CDN geography, not image optimisation.
INP INP 20	Field: good 200 ms / poor 500 ms. Lab proxy via TBT: 200 ms / 600 ms , labelled as an estimate.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL INP is CPU-bound, so the offshore penalty barely applies. Device mix is comparable.	No change.
CLS CLS 18	Good ≤ 0.1 / poor 0.25. Bands surfaced as 0–0.1 pass, 0.1–0.25 warning, 0.25+ fail.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change. Layout stability is geography-independent.
FCP FCP 8	Log-normal, good 1800 ms / poor 3000 ms.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL Inherits the same offshore-latency floor as TTFB.	No change.
TTFB TTFB 8	Log-normal, good 800 ms / poor 1800 ms. Also carries hygiene weight 8.	IDENTICAL Domestic RTT is roughly 20–60 ms, so 800 ms is comfortable.	DATA Same 800 ms bar, but Sydney→US-West RTT is roughly 150–200 ms and Sydney→US-East roughly 200–250 ms. DNS, TCP, TLS and the request each pay it before the server does any work.	Highest-value AU insight in this pillar. Detect origin/CDN geography and raise a distinct finding when an AU-market site resolves to US-only infrastructure. Do not move the threshold.
TBT TBT	Lab only. Good 200 ms / poor 600 ms.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change.

Parameter	Norm the engine scores against	US	AU	Action
Speed Index SI 6	Lab only. Good 3400 ms / poor 5800 ms.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change.
Compression Compression hyg 4	Brotli or gzip on text assets; scored on the share of compressible bytes actually compressed.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL Worth more in practice — every byte saved avoids a high-latency round trip.	No threshold change; optionally raise recommendation priority for offshore-hosted AU sites.
Caching Caching hyg 4	Cache-Control presence, TTL adequacy, immutable static assets.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change.
Resource optimisation Resource_Optimization hyg 5	Image sizing and format, unused CSS/JS, oversized payloads.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change.
Render blocking Render_Blocking hyg 5	Log-normal on estimated blocking time, good 300 ms / poor 1200 ms.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change.
Redirect chains Redirect_Chains hyg 3	Counts hops on the landing path; each hop costs one round trip.	IDENTICAL A 3-hop chain costs roughly 150 ms domestically.	DATA Same pass/fail, but the same 3-hop chain to a US origin costs roughly 600 ms.	Same rule. Use a market-aware RTT constant when you quantify the cost, so the recommendation is credible.
Sold vehicle handling Sold_Vehicle hyg 5 · VDP/SRP	Sold VDPs should 301 or 410, not 404 or soft-404. Load-time component graded 4000 ms / 8000 ms.	CONVENTION Fast inventory turn.	CONVENTION Identical expectation. Smaller AU inventories mean stale sold pages linger longer and show up more often.	No rule change; expect the finding to fire more often in AU.
Delivery hygiene Delivery_Hygiene info · composite	Composite of TTFB 8, Render_Blocking 5, Resource_Optimization 5, Compression 4, Caching 4, Redirect_Chains 3, plus Sold_Vehicle 5 on VDP/SRP. Deliberately excluded from the headline so a PSI cross-check compares like for like.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL Worth adding one sub-signal: does the CDN actually have an AU point of presence?	Additive AU sub-check only.

One operational difference to handle: Australia's traffic volumes are a fraction of the US, so more AU dealer origins fall **below the CrUX reporting threshold** and have no field data. Make sure that path degrades to lab-only with an honest confidence flag — it must never score as a failure.

WCAG is a W3C standard, so every success criterion is the same number in both countries. Exactly one parameter can legitimately differ, and it happens to be a Critical-tier one. Everything else that changes is the **authority you cite** and the **severity story** you tell.

How the pillar scores

Severity-weighted roll-up: **Critical x3, Serious x2, Moderate x1**. A single Critical failure caps the headline at **70**; a Serious failure caps it at **85**. A clean automated scan tops out at **90** (`AUTOMATED_CEILING`) because automated tooling covers only ~30–40% of WCAG — the pillar is never allowed to claim full compliance. Per-failing-element deductions are **critical 6, serious 5, moderate 2, minor 0.75**, capped per rule at **30 / 25 / 10 / 4**. Non-axe DOM probes (target size, reflow, skip links, landmarks, affordance) are halved via `PROBE_WEIGHT_FACTOR 0.5` and capped at the minor cap. Axe-backed parameters grade on the **ratio of passing to passing+failing nodes**, not pass/fail, and a check with no applicable elements is renormalised out rather than scored 0.

The two legal regimes

Dimension	What it means for scoring	United States	Australia	Action
Governing law	Sets the conformance target the report should cite.	LEGAL ADA Title III for commercial sites; Section 508 for federal; DOJ's 2024 Title II rule adopts WCAG 2.1 AA for state and local government.	LEGAL Disability Discrimination Act 1992 s24; AHRC <i>World Wide Web Access</i> advisory notes point to WCAG 2.1 AA ; AS EN 301 549 is the procurement standard; Digital Service Standard for government.	Same target level. Swap the cited authority or AU findings read as US boilerplate.
Enforcement	Drives how you frame severity to a customer.	LEGAL High-volume private litigation and demand letters, concentrated in NY, FL and CA. Immediate financial exposure.	LEGAL Complaint-driven conciliation via the AHRC, escalating to the Federal Court. Precedent: <i>Maguire v SOCOG</i> (2000). Far lower volume.	Do not change scores. Change the business case: litigation trigger vs complaint and reputational risk.

Parameters

Parameter	Norm the engine scores against	US	AU	Action
Colour contrast <code>Color_Contrast</code> Critical x3	WCAG 1.4.3 — 4.5:1 normal text, 3:1 large text. Graded on the share of passing nodes; per-rule deduction capped at 30.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change.
Form labels <code>Label</code> Critical x3	WCAG 1.3.1 / 3.3.2 — every input has a programmatic label. Renormalised out entirely when the page has no inputs.	IDENTICAL Elevated stakes on credit applications (also a GLBA-adjacent surface).	IDENTICAL Elevated stakes on finance enquiry forms under the DDA.	No change. Both markets justify the finance-form severity boost.

Parameter	Norm the engine scores against	US	AU	Action
Page language Html_Has_Lang Critical x3	WCAG 3.1.1 — a valid language attribute on <code><html></code> . Bare <code>en</code> currently passes.	CONVENTION <code>en-US</code> is best practice; <code>en</code> is accepted.	CONVENTION <code>en-AU</code> is correct and changes how screen readers pronounce place names, currency and dates.	The one genuinely market-sensitive a11y parameter. Consider a warning-level sub-check: lang present <i>and</i> regionally correct for the audited market.
Keyboard navigation Keyboard_Navigation Critical x3	WCAG 2.1.1 composite. Fails if any sub-check fails: logical focus order, all interactive elements focusable, no positive <code>tabindex</code> , no focusable nodes inside <code>aria-hidden</code> .	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change.
Image alt text Image_Alt Serious x2	WCAG 1.1.1 — graded on the ratio of images with valid alt.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change; only the wording inside alt text follows local vocabulary.
Link name Link_Name Serious x2	WCAG 2.4.4 / 4.1.2 — every link exposes a discernible accessible name.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change.
Button name Button_Name Serious x2	WCAG 4.1.2 — every button exposes a discernible accessible name.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change.
ARIA roles Aria_Roles Serious x2	WCAG 4.1.2 — roles are valid and applied to permitted elements.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change.
ARIA allowed attributes Aria_Allowed_Attr Serious x2	WCAG 4.1.2 — no ARIA attributes that the element's role disallows.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change.
Document title Document_Title Serious x2	WCAG 2.4.2 — a non-empty, descriptive <code><title></code> .	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change.
Meta viewport Meta_Viewport Serious x2	WCAG 1.4.4 — zoom must not be disabled (<code>user-scalable=no</code> or a low <code>maximum-scale</code> fails).	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change.
Target size Target_Size Serious x2 · probe	WCAG 2.2 SC 2.5.8 — touch targets at least 24x24 CSS pixels . Non-axe DOM probe, so its deduction is halved and capped at the minor cap.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change.

Parameter	Norm the engine scores against	US	AU	Action
Reflow Reflow Serious $\times 2$ · probe	WCAG 1.4.10 — no two-dimensional scrolling at 320 CSS px width. Non-axe probe, same halving.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change.
Heading order Heading_Order Moderate $\times 1$	WCAG 1.3.1 — heading levels increase by one without skipping.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change.
Landmarks Landmarks Moderate $\times 1$ · probe	Graded by the share of expected regions present — main , nav , header , footer . A missing <code><main></code> is called out explicitly.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change.
Lists List Moderate $\times 1$	WCAG 1.3.1 — list markup is well-formed. Renormalised out when the page has no lists.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change.
Skip links Skip_Links Moderate $\times 1$ · probe	A bypass mechanism to main content (WCAG 2.4.1). Non-axe probe.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change.
Interactive affordance Interactive_Element_Affordance Moderate $\times 1$ · probe	Interactive elements look interactive — cursor, focus ring, hover state.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change.
WCAG AA summary WCAG_AA_Compliance info · 0	Roll-up of axe violations mapped to WCAG 2.2 AA criteria. Reported, not separately weighted.	IDENTICAL Cite ADA / Section 508.	IDENTICAL Cite DDA / AHRC / AS EN 301 549.	Change the citation only.
Focus order Focus_Order sub-check	WCAG 2.4.3. Reported individually; scored inside <code>Keyboard_Navigation</code> .	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change.
Focusable content Focusable_Content sub-check	WCAG 2.1.1 — all interactive elements reachable by keyboard.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change.
Tab index Tab_Index sub-check	No positive <code>tabindex</code> values.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change.
aria-hidden focus Aria_Hidden_Focus sub-check	No focusable nodes inside an <code>aria-hidden</code> subtree.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change.

Parameter	Norm the engine scores against	US	AU	Action
Text spacing Text_Spacing info · 0	WCAG 1.4.12. Flagged as a manual-review check; weight 0 because automation cannot confirm it.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change.
Focus not obscured Focus_Not_Obscured info · 0	WCAG 2.2 SC 2.4.11. Manual-review, weight 0.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change.
Reduced motion Reduced_Motion info · 0	Honours prefers-reduced-motion . Manual-review, weight 0.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change.

One AU-relevant check worth adding: locale-mismatched form validation — a US state dropdown, a 5-digit ZIP mask, or an MM/DD placeholder on an Australian site. It is both an accessibility defect (WCAG 3.3.1/3.3.3 error identification) and a conversion defect, and it is very common on ported US dealer platforms.

06 Pillar 4 — Security & Compliance · 25 parameters · 18 identical · 7 changed · ≈26% of weight at risk

Two halves with opposite behaviour. Transport and headers are global engineering practice — 18 parameters, zero differences. Privacy, consent, finance-form and disclaimer checks sit on two different legal systems and produce both false positives and false passes if run with the wrong rule set. Weights below are out of a **114-point** maximum (finance and disclaimer parameters only apply on relevant page types).

Transport, headers and application surface — no market difference

Parameter	Norm the engine scores against	US	AU	Action
HTTPS HTTPS 13 · gate	Highest-weighted parameter and a gate . Checks the landed URL after redirects, then scans the rendered DOM for insecure subresources — active (script, stylesheet, iframe) and passive (img, media, srcset). Non-HTTPS = hard 0.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL ACSC treats HTTPS as mandatory baseline.	No change.
SSL SSL 7	Valid certificate and complete chain.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change.
SSL expiry SSL_Expiry 4	Days remaining: expired = 0 · <14 days = 50 · <30 days = 80 · ≥30 days = 100. Not-applicable when expiry data is unavailable.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change.
TLS version TLS_Version 5	TLS 1.2 minimum, 1.3 preferred . Older versions fail.	IDENTICAL Reference: NIST SP 800-52 Rev 2.	IDENTICAL Reference: ACSC Information Security Manual — same minimum, approved cipher suites.	Same threshold; swap the cited standard.
HSTS HSTS 5	<code>Strict-Transport-Security</code> present with an adequate <code>max-age</code> .	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL Explicitly recommended by the ISM.	No change.
CSP CSP 9	Graded, not binary: starts at 40 for being present at all , then builds toward 100 as directives tighten. OWASP Secure Headers baseline.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change.
X-Frame-Options X_Frame_Options 4	Present with <code>DENY / SAMEORIGIN</code> , or equivalent CSP <code>frame-ancestors</code> .	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change.

Parameter	Norm the engine scores against	US	AU	Action
X-Content-Type-Options X_Content_Type_Options 3	nosniff present.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change.
Referrer-Policy Referrer_Policy 2	Present and privacy-preserving.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change.
Permissions-Policy Permissions_Policy 2	Present and restricting powerful features.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change.
Header security Header_Security composite	Roll-up card over the six header parameters. Returned for display; the individual headers carry the weight.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change.
Cookie flags Cookie_Flags 5	Secure and HttpOnly are the protective flags; SameSite (CSRF) is weighted lighter within the check.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change to the flags. Consent is a separate question — see below.
Reputation Reputation 9 · gate	Google Safe Browsing + VirusTotal, merged into one weighted signal with the sources kept as evidence. Requires API keys; gated.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL Same global feeds.	No change.
SQLi exposure SQLi_Exposure 4	Non-invasive surface indicator — an exposure signal, explicitly not proof of vulnerability.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL Cite ACSC Essential Eight alongside OWASP.	No change.
XSS XSS 4	Same non-invasive surface-indicator model.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change.
Forms use HTTPS Forms_Use_HTTPS 4	Every form <code>action</code> posts to an HTTPS endpoint.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change.
Weak default credentials Weak_Default_Credentials 2	Surface indicator for default admin credentials.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change.
Admin panel public Admin_Panel_Public 1	Publicly reachable admin path.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change.

Parameter	Norm the engine scores against	United States	Australia	Action
MFA MFA_Enabled 1	Heuristic — evidence of multi-factor authentication on customer-facing accounts.	LEGAL Explicitly mandated. The FTC Safeguards Rule (16 CFR 314) requires MFA for anyone accessing customer information, and names auto dealers as covered financial institutions.	LEGAL Not named in statute for dealers. APP 11 requires "reasonable steps"; the ACSC Essential Eight lists MFA as a core mitigation — de facto expected, framed as reasonableness.	Keep the check in both. US: state a regulatory requirement. AU: frame as the expected reasonable step under APP 11 / Essential Eight.
Third-party cookies Third_Party_Cookies 2	Counts and classifies third-party cookies set on load.	LEGAL Ad-tech cookies can be a "sale" or "share" under CPRA, triggering the opt-out link and Global Privacy Control obligations.	LEGAL No "sale" concept. The exposure is APP 8 cross-border disclosure — sending personal information to US vendors, for which the dealer stays accountable.	Same detection. Different explanation and remediation. Surface the actual vendor domains so an AU privacy policy can name them.
Cookie consent Cookie_Consent 3	Looks for a consent mechanism before non-essential cookies are set.	LEGAL No banner mandate. The requirement is an opt-out : a "Do Not Sell or Share My Personal Information" link, a sensitive-PI limit control, and honouring GPC in CA, CO, CT and other opt-out states. Separately, CIPA claims currently target session recording and pixels.	LEGAL Australia has no cookie law. Obligations come from the APPs: notify at collection (APP 5), collect only what is reasonably necessary (APP 3), consent for sensitive information. A banner is good practice, not a legal requirement.	Biggest false-positive risk in the product. Do not score an AU site down for having no banner. Replace with: AU → privacy policy discloses tracking and overseas disclosure; US → opt-out link present and GPC honoured. Caveat: GDPR still applies if the site serves EU/UK visitors.
Privacy policy Privacy_Policy 3	Presence and reachability of a privacy policy, plus required-content keywords.	LEGAL CalOPPA requires a policy where Californian personal information is collected; CCPA/CPRA prescribes content — categories, purposes, retention, sources, disclosures, rights, notice at collection. Around twenty state laws overlap.	LEGAL APP 1.3 requires a clearly expressed, up-to-date, free and readily available policy with prescribed content: kinds of information, collection and holding, purposes, access and correction, how to complain , and whether information goes overseas and to which countries . Small-business exemption below AU\$3m turnover, which most dealer groups exceed.	Different content checklist. AU adds two simple text checks with high compliance value: named overseas-disclosure countries, and a complaints/OAIC escalation path.

Parameter	Norm the engine scores against	United States	Australia	Action
Privacy compliance Privacy_Compliance 4	Currently binary-ish: both regime checks pass = 100; one passes = 70 (warning); neither = 0 (fail).	LEGAL Heavy sectoral overlay for dealers: GLBA (dealers arranging finance are financial institutions), FCRA (permissible purpose, adverse action, risk-based pricing), DPPA (motor-vehicle record data). Breach notification is state-by-state plus FTC for qualifying Safeguards events.	LEGAL One national regime: Privacy Act 1988 + 13 APPs , regulator OAIC. Notifiable Data Breaches — assess within 30 days, notify OAIC and individuals. The 2024 amendment added a statutory tort for serious invasions of privacy, automated-decision transparency, and a Children's Online Privacy Code.	Different checklist entirely. AU additions: named overseas recipients, OAIC complaint path, NDB acknowledgement, and an automated-decision disclosure where the site offers instant finance pre-approval.
Finance form security Finance_Form_Security 10 · page-specific	Heaviest page-specific parameter. HTTPS post target, no plaintext transmission, no PII in query strings, autocomplete hygiene on credit-application forms. Renormalised out when no finance page exists.	LEGAL GLBA Safeguards Rule — written information security program, encryption in transit and at rest, MFA, access control, vendor oversight, incident response, a named accountable individual, FTC notification for qualifying breaches.	LEGAL APP 11 reasonable steps plus NCCP obligations on credit assistance providers and ASIC conduct rules. Credit applications capture identity documents — driver licence data — which raises the APP 11 bar. NDB applies to any breach.	The DOM checks stay the same . Authority and severity language change. Add an AU sub-check: licence or ID upload without a collection notice at the point of capture.
Legal disclaimers Legal_Disclaimers 8 · page-specific	Term-group detection with per-page-type requirements: finance page → finance + price · specials → price + expiry · lease → lease + price · VDP → price . Expiry group looks for "offer ends", "valid until", "while supplies last", "must take delivery".	LEGAL Reg Z (TILA) 1026.24 — a stated triggering term (down payment, payment amount, term, finance charge) forces full terms including APR. Reg M for leases. FTC Used Car Rule Buyers Guide. Fee rules vary by state. <i>The FTC CARS Rule was vacated by the Fifth Circuit in January 2025 — confirm status before citing.</i>	LEGAL ACL s48 total price including GST, at least as prominent as any component. ACL s18/s29 misleading conduct. Consumer guarantees cannot be excluded , so "sold as is" or "no refunds" wording is itself a breach. National Credit Code — comparison rate plus warning where a rate is advertised, and the Australian Credit Licence number displayed. State acts require the dealer licence number in advertising , plus statutory used-car warranty and cooling-off disclosures.	Separate rule set, not a translation. AU is actually easier to automate — the required elements are concrete strings: total/drive-away price, comparison rate, credit licence number, dealer licence number, consumer-guarantees statement, cooling-off notice.

Two AU-only parameters worth adding here.

- 1. Overseas disclosure statement** — does the privacy policy name the countries personal information is disclosed to (APP 1.3(f))? Almost universally missing on dealer sites running US-hosted CRM, chat and analytics, and you already detect those vendors in [Third_Party_Cookies](#) and [CRM_Integration](#).
- 2. Credit licence and comparison rate** — where a page advertises finance with a rate, are the ACL number and comparison rate present? A hard legal requirement with no US equivalent and no current check.

Proportionally the most exposed pillar. Every mechanical check is identical — the answer engines crawl with the same user agents in both countries. But nine parameters compare against a reference list of identifiers, directories, authorities and credentials, and every one of those lists is American. Each signal has a **20-second budget**; a timeout returns not-calculated and is renormalised out, never scored as 50.

Parameter	Norm the engine scores against	US	AU	Action
Schema markup Schema_Markup 0.20	Heaviest AEO parameter. Page-appropriate types present and valid: <code>AutoDealer</code> , <code>Vehicle / Car</code> , <code>Offer</code> , <code>FAQPage</code> , <code>BreadcrumbList</code> , with required vs recommended field validation per type.	CONVENTION <code>priceCurrency</code> : "USD", mileage <code>SMI</code> , price typically excludes tax.	CONVENTION Same types and syntax. <code>priceCurrency</code> : "AUD", mileage <code>KMT</code> , <code>price</code> should be the GST-inclusive total to match ACL s48. Extras: <code>identifier</code> carrying the ABN, <code>areaServed</code> naming suburbs/states.	Validator unchanged; expected values market-aware. Flag USD or SMI on an AU site as a mis-localised template — common and highly visible on ported platforms.
Answer-first structure Answer_First_Structure 0.15	A direct answer in the opening passage and question-shaped headings, rather than a marketing preamble.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL Question phrasing differs — "What's the drive-away price?", "Does it come with a roadworthy?"	No structural change; add AU phrasings to the question-pattern library.
Bot access Bot_Access 0.11	Per-engine crawlability, averaged inside the signal: GPTBot, ClaudeBot, PerplexityBot, Google-Extended, CCBot, Bingbot — plus WAF and Cloudflare rules not blocking them.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL Same user agents, same robots.txt semantics (RFC 9309).	No change. The two markets differ on text-and-data-mining copyright policy, but nothing on the page changes.
Structured content Structured_Content 0.09	Machine-parseable tables and lists rather than specification data baked into images.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change.
E-E-A-T composite EEAT_Composite 0.10 · page-specific	Applies on About, Blog and Service pages only. One weighted composite of Experience, Expertise and Authority signals — deliberately consolidated so dealer authority is not triple-counted.	DATA Author bios, ASE -certified technicians, NADA and state association membership, BBB rating, manufacturer certified status, years in business.	DATA Dealer licence number (statutory credibility), ABN , AADA , state motor trades associations (VACC, MTA-NSW, MTA-QLD, MTA-SA, MTA-WA), manufacturer authorised dealer, RACV / NRMA / RACQ approval. No ASE, no NADA, no BBB exists in Australia.	Swap the credential dictionary. This is where a US-tuned engine most visibly misreads a legitimate Australian dealer as unqualified.
FAQ / Q&A blocks FAQ_QA_Blocks 0.07 · page-specific	Applies to FAQ, Finance, Service and VDP pages. Coverage of expected buyer questions in a parseable Q&A structure.	DATA Expected topics: financing and APR, trade-in, warranty, service, delivery, CARFAX history, doc fees.	DATA Expected topics: drive-away price and on-road costs, comparison rate, PPSR check , roadworthy / safety certificate, statutory warranty and cooling-off, rego transfer, stamp duty, RedBook trade-in, novated leasing.	Swap the expected-topic list. AU buyers ask materially different questions; a strong AU FAQ currently reads as incomplete.

Parameter	Norm the engine scores against	US	AU	Action
Entity recognition Entity_Recognition 0.07	Organization schema completeness plus Knowledge Graph presence. Also feeds the derived SameAs_Validation score.	DATA Organization schema, Knowledge Graph, Wikidata. EIN and DUNS exist but are rarely public-facing.	DATA Same schema signals, but the strongest anchor is the ABN — a public, resolvable government identifier via ABN Lookup — plus the ACN and state dealer licence number.	Add an ABN sub-signal. Verifiable government identifiers are exactly the grounding an answer engine rewards, and the US has no displayed equivalent.
Citation / NAP consistency Citation_NAP_Consistency 0.06	Distinct phone numbers and addresses reconciled across schema, footer and tel: links. Already detects AU via .au TLD, state tokens (NSW/VIC/QLD/...), locale and schema country, and switches phone parsing accordingly.	DATA Consistency across GBP, Yelp, Cars.com, DealerRater, BBB, Apple Maps, Bing Places.	DATA Consistency across GBP, carsales.com.au, Autotrader.com.au, CarsGuide, Drive, Yellow Pages AU, True Local, Hotfrog, Localsearch, ProductReview.com.au, ABN Lookup. Yelp and BBB are not meaningful in AU.	Country detection already exists — extend the same idea to the directory list , and finish the address normaliser so AU addresses parse.
Citations & attribution Citations_Attribution 0.05	Outbound links to recognised authoritative sources, and whether claims are attributed.	DATA NHTSA recalls, EPA fuel economy, IIHS safety ratings, KBB, Edmunds, manufacturer press sites.	DATA ANCAP safety ratings, Green Vehicle Guide , PPSR , RedBook , ACCC , Vehicle Recalls Australia, state road authorities (Service NSW, VicRoads, TMR Queensland).	Swap the authority whitelist. An AU dealer linking to ANCAP is doing exactly the right thing and currently gets no credit.
Topical authority Topical_Authority 0.05	Depth plus topic clustering, with a local-authority component worth up to 15 points — locality/region terms, "near me", areaServed, directions. Fewer than 10 of those points triggers a weak-local-signals issue.	DATA City, state, metro and county terms.	DATA Suburbs as the primary unit, then capital cities, state codes, and regional names (Gold Coast, Hunter Valley, Northern Beaches).	Inherits the AU gazetteer. No separate work once that asset exists.
Index coverage Index_Coverage 0.04	Index eligibility — real Search Console data where available, otherwise a sitemap-based estimate.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change.
sameAs validation SameAs_Validation 0.04 · page-specific	Home and About pages. Breadth and validity of sameAs profile links, derived from the entity-recognition signal.	DATA Facebook, Instagram, YouTube, X, LinkedIn, Yelp, GBP, Cars.com, DealerRater.	DATA Facebook, Instagram, YouTube, LinkedIn, GBP, carsales.com.au, Autotrader.com.au, ProductReview.com.au, ABN Lookup. Marketplace presence weighs more in AU because carsales dominates vehicle search.	Swap the expected-profile list or AU dealers are penalised for missing platforms that do not exist locally.
llms.txt Llms_Txt 0.02	Present at /llms.txt, well-formed, and pointing at real content.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change.

Parameter	Norm the engine scores against	US	AU	Action
Brand entity strength Brand_Entity_Strength info · 0	Weight deliberately zero — it was triple-counting dealer authority alongside E-E-A-T and entity recognition.	DATA Mentions across US media, Knowledge Panel, Wikipedia/Wikidata.	DATA Mentions across AU motoring press (Drive, CarsGuide, CarExpert, WhichCar), local news, ABN Lookup.	Reference corpus changes; stays informational.
Markdown structure Markdown_Structure info · 0	Heading structure legibility for LLM parsing. Informational.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change.
Page speed Page_Speed info · 0	Mirror of the Technical performance score. Informational to avoid double-counting.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change.

Per-engine view. The pillar also computes separate Gemini, ChatGPT and Perplexity scores. Those use the same signals with different weightings and are equally market-neutral in mechanics — the same eight reference lists feed them, so fixing the lists fixes the per-engine gauges at the same time.

Measures how well a machine can parse, ground and re-use the page. The parsing rules are language-model behaviour, not local practice, so the logic is market-neutral. Only the dictionaries change.

Parameter	Norm the engine scores against	US	AU	Action
Structured data Structured_Data 0.20	Heaviest AIO parameter. Parses every <code>application/ld+json</code> block (stripping CDATA and comments), counts successfully parsed blocks, walks <code>@graph</code> and nested objects for <code>@type</code> , and counts syntax errors separately.	CONVENTION USD, imperial units.	CONVENTION Same validity rules; AUD, metric units, GST-inclusive price, ABN identifier.	Validation unchanged; expected values market-aware. Shares the fix with AEO <code>Schema_Markup</code> .
NLP-friendly content Content_NLP_Friendly 0.16	Clear sentence construction, resolvable pronouns, entities named rather than implied, no text trapped in images.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL AU acronyms (RWC, PPSR, LMCT, CTP, ANCAP, rego) should be expanded on first use — models ground better on the full term.	Optional AU sub-check for unexpanded local acronyms. Genuinely useful, not cosmetic.
Answer-oriented structure Answer_Oriented_Structure 0.12	Content organised as extractable answers rather than continuous prose.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change.
Keywords & entities annotated Keywords_Entities_Annotated 0.10	Named entities — makes, models, trims, locations — recognisable and consistently referenced.	DATA US make/model/trim taxonomy, including nameplates sold only in the US.	DATA A materially different line-up: Toyota HiLux, Ford Ranger, Isuzu D-MAX, Mitsubishi Triton , Holden (legacy), and the newer LDV, GWM, Chery, MG, BYD . Trims are called variants or badges .	Swap the vehicle taxonomy. A US dictionary fails to recognise a large share of Australian inventory and materially under-scores AU sites.
Content updated regularly Content_Updated_Regularly 0.10	Freshness markers in schema and visible copy; recency of the most reliable date found.	IDENTICAL Visible dates MM/DD/YYYY.	IDENTICAL Visible dates DD/MM/YYYY — a US-shaped parser misreads or rejects them.	Make the date parser locale-aware. The freshness rule itself is unchanged.
Internal linking (AI-friendly) Internal_Linking_AI_Friendly 0.10	Descriptive anchors and a topic-cluster shape a model can follow.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change.
Topical focus clarity Topical_Focus_Clarity 0.10	One clear subject per page rather than a diffuse mix.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change.

Parameter	Norm the engine scores against	US	AU	Action
AI agentic browsing AI_Agentic_Browsing 0.06	WebMCP / agent-navigable structure. Its agent-accessibility, CLS and lms.txt sub-scores stay informational because Accessibility, Technical and AEO already own them.	IDENTICAL No federal AI statute; state laws (California AI transparency, Colorado AI Act) target disclosure and high-risk decisions.	IDENTICAL Voluntary AI Safety Standard (10 guardrails); mandatory guardrails for high-risk AI under consultation.	No technical change. Diverges only if you start scoring AI-disclosure duties — for example a chat assistant that must identify itself as AI.
Duplicate-content readiness Duplicate_Content_Detection_Ready info · 0	Whether the page gives a model enough signal to detect duplication. Informational.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change.
Structured content Structured_Content info · 0	Informational here; AEO owns the weighted version.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change.
Terminology consistency Terminology_Consistency info · 0	The same concept named the same way throughout the page and site.	CONVENTION Consistent US terms: pre-owned, MSRP, miles, MPG, trunk.	CONVENTION Consistent AU terms: used / second-hand, drive-away, kilometres, L/100km, boot, ute. Mixing markets is the common failure — a ported platform saying "miles" on one page and "km" on another.	Add cross-market contamination detection: US-only terms (MSRP, MPG, ZIP code, trunk, gas, license plate, CARFAX) appearing on an AU-market site. Distinctive, cheap, and instantly credible to a customer — worth promoting off weight 0.

Australian and American car buyers use the same devices and the same mental models, so layout and interaction norms carry over unchanged. The differences are in **what a nav bar is expected to contain**, **what a filter is expected to filter by**, and **what a gallery is expected to show**.

Parameter	Norm the engine scores against	US	AU	Action
Intrusive interstitials Intrusive_Interstitials 0.11	Joint-heaviest. Google's mobile interstitial guidance — content obscured on load fails.	IDENTICAL Often a CCPA notice.	IDENTICAL Often a promo or chat prompt.	No change.
Navigation discoverability Navigation_Discoverability 0.11	Primary navigation present, reachable and covering the expected sections for a dealer site.	CONVENTION New / Used / Certified Pre-Owned / Service / Parts / Finance / Specials / About.	CONVENTION New / Demo / Used / Service / Parts / Finance / Specials / About. "Demo" is a distinct AU inventory class with no US equivalent; CPO is manufacturer-specific and far less prominent.	Market-aware expected-item list. Penalising an AU site for missing "Certified Pre-Owned" is a false finding; missing "Demo" is a real gap.
Broken links Broken_Links 0.11	Sampled link crawl; scored on the share resolving successfully.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change.
Text readability Text_Readability 0.10	Flesch Reading Ease computed as 206.835 – (1.015 × avg sentence length) – (84.6 × avg syllables per word) , over the whole page and per paragraph (paragraphs longer than 50 characters), with page-type awareness.	CONVENTION Target around grade 8 ; Plain Writing Act 2010 sets the government tone.	CONVENTION Same formula — Flesch is calibrated on English generally, not US English. The Australian Government Style Manual recommends around Year 7 reading level: effectively the same target, differently named.	Relabel only. Say "Year 7 reading level" in AU reports. The score does not move, and syllable heuristics behave identically across both spellings.
Inventory filtering Inventory_Filtering 0.10	Facet coverage and usability on search-results pages.	CONVENTION Make, model, trim, year, price, mileage (miles) , body style, fuel, transmission, drivetrain, colour, MPG , features, distance from ZIP.	CONVENTION Make, model, badge/variant , year, price, kilometres , body type including ute and wagon, fuel, transmission, 4x4 / AWD / 2WD (a very prominent AU filter), colour, L/100km , ANCAP rating , seats, new/demo/used, location by suburb or state — plus a drive-away vs excluding-on-roads price toggle .	Market-aware expected-facet list. The price toggle and drivetrain prominence are close to table stakes on AU marketplaces.

Parameter	Norm the engine scores against	US	AU	Action
Vehicle image gallery Vehicle_Image_Gallery 0.10	Image count, angle coverage and gallery usability on VDPs.	CONVENTION Multiple angles, interior, odometer, VIN plate, Monroney window sticker on new, CARFAX badge.	CONVENTION Same photo expectations, plus AU artefacts buyers look for: compliance plate , rego label, service-book photos, and the fuel-consumption label on new vehicles. No Monroney sticker exists in Australia.	Market-aware expected-shot checklist. Requiring a window sticker on an AU VDP is a false finding.
Above-the-fold content Above_the_Fold_Content 0.09	ATF score ≥ 50 = pass , ≥ 20 = warning , below = fail . Measures meaningful content in the first viewport.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change.
Mobile experience Mobile_Experience 0.09	Mobile viewport rendering, tap-target sanity and layout behaviour at mobile widths.	IDENTICAL Roughly 60–70% of dealer traffic.	IDENTICAL Comparable or slightly higher mobile share; same devices.	No change.
Hierarchy & flow clarity Hierarchy_Flow_Clarity 0.07	Score ≥ 90 = pass , ≥ 60 = warning . Visual and structural hierarchy consistency.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change.
Interactive click feedback Interactive_Click_Feedback 0.06	Feedback score ≥ 80 = pass , ≥ 50 = warning . Interactive elements acknowledge input.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change.
No-results UX No_Results_UX 0.06	Empty search states offer recovery paths rather than a dead end.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change.
Loading feedback Loading_Feedback 0.05	Skeletons, spinners or progress indication during async work.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL Matters slightly more where the origin is offshore and waits are longer.	No change.
Content density balance Content_Density_Balance 0.05	Text-to-whitespace balance, with separate thresholds for mobile and desktop ; out-of-band density scores 60.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change.
Layout consistency Layout_Consistency 0.05	Consistent spacing, alignment and component treatment across the page.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change.
Sticky header usage Sticky_Header_Usage 0.05	Persistent navigation without stealing excessive viewport height.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change.

Parameter	Norm the engine scores against	US	AU	Action
Breadcrumbs Breadcrumbs 0.05	Breadcrumb trail present and reflecting real hierarchy.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change.
In-page navigation In_Page_Navigation 0.04	Anchor navigation and jump links on long pages.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change.

The largest pillar and the most divergent in absolute terms. Form and CTA mechanics are universal. Everything touching **price, finance, vehicle history, valuation and outbound contact** sits on different legal foundations and different provider ecosystems.

CTAs and forms — mechanics carry over

Parameter	Norm the engine scores against	US	AU	Action
CTA presence CTA_Presence 0.07	Binary today: any element matching a broad CTA selector set (buttons, <code>.cta</code> , <code>.btn-primary</code> , hero/promo links, signup/register/subscribe hrefs) → 100; none → 0.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change.
CTA flow alignment CTA_Flow_Alignment 0.06	CTA intent matches the page's stage in the buying journey.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change.
CTA clarity CTA_Clarity 0.05	Scores the share of CTAs (text ≤30 chars) containing a clear action verb. The current list is buy, get, download, sign up, subscribe, start, join, register, learn, book, order .	CONVENTION "Get ePrice", "Value Your Trade", "Check Availability", "Get Pre-Qualified", "Schedule Service".	CONVENTION "Enquire Now" is the dominant AU lead verb, plus "Book a Test Drive", "Get a Drive-Away Price", "Trade-In Valuation", "Book a Service".	Extend the verb list. "Enquire" is absent today, so nearly every Australian dealer's primary CTA is scored as unclear — a visible false negative.
CTA crowding CTA_Crowding 0.05	Too many competing CTAs in one region dilutes action.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change.
Form presence Form_Presence 0.09 · page-specific	A lead-capture form exists on pages where one is expected.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change.
Form length Form_Length 0.04	Counts <code>input</code> , <code>select</code> , <code>textarea</code> per form. Fewer than 7 fields = optimal; 7 or more is flagged as a long form.	IDENTICAL Expected fields include ZIP and 2-letter state.	IDENTICAL Expected fields: 4-digit postcode, 8-option state, <code>+61</code> phone. Data-minimisation pressure is higher — APP 3 limits collection to what is reasonably necessary.	Threshold unchanged. In AU you can additionally justify the shorter-form recommendation on APP 3 grounds, which lands well with customers.
Required vs optional fields Required_vs_Optional_Fields 0.04	Required fields are marked and genuinely necessary.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL Same APP 3 reinforcement.	No change.

Parameter	Norm the engine scores against	US	AU	Action
Inline validation Inline_Validation 0.05	Field-level validation before submit rather than a post-submit error page.	IDENTICAL Validates 5-digit ZIP, US state list, MM/DD dates.	IDENTICAL Must validate 4-digit postcode, AU states, DD/MM dates, +61 and 1300 / 13 numbers.	Same scoring. Add a locale-mismatch check — a US state dropdown or ZIP mask on an AU site is a real defect.
Submit button clarity Submit_Button_Clarity 0.025	Submit label states the outcome, not "Submit".	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL Shares the CTA verb list — "Enquire" applies here too.	Inherits the CTA verb fix.
Multi-step progress MultiStep_Form_Progress 0.015	Multi-step forms show position and remaining steps.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change.
Friendly error handling Friendly_Error_Handling 0.02	Errors explain the fix in plain language and preserve entered data.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change beyond locale-aware validation messages.
Microcopy clarity Microcopy_Clarity 0.02	Helper text sets expectations — what happens after submit, who makes contact, how soon.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL Date placeholders must read DD/MM to avoid genuine ambiguity.	No scoring change.
Thank-you pages Thank_You_Pages 0.03	A distinct post-submit confirmation state — also the conversion-tracking anchor.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change.

Trust and social proof — different ecosystems

Parameter	Norm the engine scores against	US	AU	Action
Trust badges Trust_Badges 0.05	Recognised trust marks near PII-collecting forms.	DATA BBB Accredited, CARFAX Advantage, AutoCheck, ASE Certified, NADA, manufacturer CPO, Google Guaranteed, security seals.	DATA Dealer licence number , ABN, AADA member, VACC / MTA-NSW / MTA-QLD / MTA-SA / MTA-WA, RACV / NRMA / RACQ approved, PPSR-checked, manufacturer authorised dealer, ANCAP. No BBB, no CARFAX, no ASE in Australia.	Swap the badge dictionary. The clearest case of a US list producing a wrong answer — an AU dealer showing its LMCT number and VACC membership is displaying strong trust signals the checker cannot see.
Testimonials Testimonials 0.04	Attributed customer testimonials present and credible.	LEGAL FTC Rule on Consumer Reviews and Testimonials (16 CFR 465) bans fake reviews, undisclosed insider reviews and review suppression, with civil penalties.	LEGAL Enforced through ACL s18/s29 and ACCC guidance on fake, incentivised and selectively-filtered reviews.	Same check; different authority cited.

Parameter	Norm the engine scores against	US	AU	Action
Reviews Reviews 0.03	Visible third-party review presence and rating.	DATA Google, DealerRater, Cars.com, Edmunds, Yelp.	DATA Google dominant, then ProductReview.com.au , carsales dealer ratings, Facebook.	Swap the platform list.
Client logos Client_Logos 0.01	Partner or brand logos as social proof.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change.
Case studies Case_Studies_Accessibility 0.01	Case studies or success stories reachable without a gate.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change.
Certifications & awards Certifications_Awards 0.01	Displayed professional credentials and awards.	DATA ASE-certified technicians, manufacturer master technician, NADA and state association awards, DealerRater awards.	DATA Certificate III in Light Vehicle Mechanical Technology, manufacturer technician accreditation, VACC/MTA accreditation, AADA and state dealer awards, ProductReview awards.	Swap the credential dictionary — shared asset with AEO EEAT_Composite .

Parameter	Norm the engine scores against	United States	Australia	Action
Trade-in flow TradeIn_Flow 0.15 · page-specific	Heaviest parameter in the pillar. Detects trade-in intent plus real form fields — requires at least 2 signal hits with actual input fields, otherwise it is treated as a mention without a tool.	DATA KBB Instant Cash Offer , Black Book, J.D. Power (formerly NADA Guides), Edmunds appraisal. Trade-in sales-tax credit varies by state and is a selling point.	DATA RedBook dominant, Glass's Guide secondary. An encumbered trade-in needs a PPSR payout settled. No trade-in tax credit — stamp duty is calculated on the purchase price.	Swap the valuation-provider dictionary. AU opportunity: check whether the flow addresses payout of existing finance — a real friction point AU sites routinely omit.
Appointment booking Appointment_Booking 0.12 · page-specific	Booking intent plus real scheduling fields (at least one signal hit with form fields present).	CONVENTION Test-drive and service booking. Licence handling constrained by DPPA and state licence-scanning laws.	CONVENTION Same flows. Driver-licence details are personal information : APP 3 limits collection to what is reasonably necessary and APP 5 requires a collection notice at the point of capture. Availability must respect state public holidays and Sunday trading.	Same UX checks. Add an AU sub-check: licence or ID capture without a collection notice or privacy link at that point.
Financing flow Financing_Flow 0.10 · page-specific	Finance intent plus real application fields (≥ 2 signal hits with fields).	LEGAL Credit application governed by GLBA (data security), FCRA (permissible purpose, adverse action, risk-based pricing) and ECOA/Reg B. Soft-pull pre-qualification is standard; FICO referenced openly.	LEGAL Arranging finance is credit assistance under the NCCP Act 2009 — requires an Australian Credit Licence or authorised-representative status, and the licence number must be disclosed. Responsible-lending obligations apply; ASIC regulates, RG 234 governs advertising.	New AU check: is an ACL number displayed on any page offering finance? Concrete, high-confidence DOM check with no US analogue.
Finance calculator Finance_Calculator 0.10 · page-specific	A working repayment calculator with inputs, not a static rate table.	LEGAL Reg Z 1026.24 — stating a triggering term (down payment, payment amount, number of payments, finance charge) forces full terms including the APR . Reg M mirrors this for leases.	LEGAL Advertising an interest rate for fixed-term consumer credit requires a comparison rate plus the prescribed warning statement . Also expected: "approval subject to lending criteria", fees and charges, the credit licence number, and no implication that a quoted repayment is an approved offer.	Different disclosure checklist per market. AU is highly checkable — look for "comparison rate", the warning statement, "fees and charges apply" and an ACL number near the calculator. US: look for APR wherever a repayment figure appears.

Parameter	Norm the engine scores against	United States	Australia	Action
Pricing transparency Pricing_Transparency 0.06 · page-specific	A price is visible on inventory pages, without a "call for price" gate.	LEGAL MSRP plus dealer fees; sales tax added later and varies by jurisdiction. "Out-the-door price" is a customer-driven norm. Fee rules are state-level; advertised-price honesty flows from FTC Act s5.	LEGAL ACL s48 single-price rule — the total minimum price, GST included, must be stated at least as prominently as any component. In practice " drive away, no more to pay " is the clean compliant form. "+ on-road costs" shown alone is a problem. ACCC actively enforces this in automotive.	Fundamentally different check. AU: prominent drive-away/total price, or an equally prominent total beside any component. US: fee disclosure and an out-the-door estimate. Running the AU rule against US pages produces mass false positives.
Vehicle history Vehicle_History 0.04 · page-specific	A history report or check is offered on used VDPs.	DATA CARFAX and AutoCheck , backed by NMVTIS title-brand data. A free CARFAX link on a used VDP is close to table stakes.	DATA PPSR certificate — finance encumbrance, written-off and stolen status; successor to the state "REVS check". Plus CarHistory.com.au. CARFAX does not operate in Australia.	Swap the provider dictionary. Detecting "PPSR checked" is the AU equivalent of the CARFAX badge, and it is the single most requested trust artefact by Australian used-car buyers.
Incentives displayed Incentives_Displayed 0.06 · page-specific	Term-group detection with per-page requirements: finance page → finance + price · specials → price + expiry · lease → lease + price · VDP → price . Expiry terms include "offer ends", "valid until", "must take delivery", "while supplies last".	LEGAL OEM rebates, subsidised APR, lease specials, conquest and loyalty cash. Reg Z/Reg M disclosures attach where triggering terms appear; expiry and eligibility must be stated.	LEGAL Drive-away deals, run-out and plate-clearance offers, factory bonuses. ACL governs: no "was/now" without a genuine prior price, conditions and end dates stated, and the total-price rule still applies to the advertised offer.	Both require expiry and conditions. AU adds the genuine-prior-price test and the total-price rule; the US adds credit-advertising disclosures.
Click to call Click_To_Call 0.04	A working <code>tel:</code> link, prominent on mobile. Numbers are normalised to the last 10 digits , and 10 digits is treated as the minimum for a real number.	CONVENTION <code>tel:+1XXXXXXXXXX</code> , 10 digits, toll-free 800-series.	CONVENTION <code>tel:+61...</code> . Landline, mobile <code>04xx</code> , and 1300 / 1800 / 13 business numbers — a <code>13 xx xx</code> number is only 6 digits .	Currently broken for AU. The 10-digit rule rejects every 13-number and mishandles the leading zero. Fixed once the phone normaliser is market-aware.
Chat experience Chat_Experience 0.03	Live chat or messaging present, responsive, and usable on mobile.	LEGAL Chat-to-SMS follow-up is governed by the TCPA — prior express written consent for automated marketing texts, with strict revocation handling. CIPA claims currently target chat-transcript vendors.	LEGAL Spam Act 2003 — consent required, sender must be identified, functional unsubscribe honoured within 5 business days . Do Not Call Register Act 2006 governs telemarketing follow-up.	Same UX checks; different consent-capture requirement.
Lead magnets Lead_Magnets 0.02	A value exchange for contact details — guide, valuation, price alert.	LEGAL CAN-SPAM is opt-out: pre-checked consent is permissible; unsubscribe honoured within 10 business days.	LEGAL Spam Act 2003 is opt-in: express or inferred consent required before sending. Pre-ticked consent boxes are not valid consent. Unsubscribe within 5 business days.	Add an AU-only check for a pre-ticked marketing consent box. A legitimate compliance finding in AU that the same check would not raise in the US.

Parameter	Norm the engine scores against	United States	Australia	Action
GA4 installed GA4_Installed 0.05	GA4 tag detected in collected tracking data.	LEGAL Same install. Overlay: CPRA opt-out and GPC handling, IAB Global Privacy Platform / MSPA signals, active CIPA litigation over session recording and pixels.	LEGAL Same install. Overlay: APP 8 cross-border disclosure — analytics is US-hosted, so the privacy policy must disclose it and the dealer stays accountable. Google Consent Mode v2 is an EEA/UK requirement, not an AU one.	Detection identical; compliance commentary changes. Do not require Consent Mode in either market on legal grounds.
GTM configuration GTM_Configuration 0.03	Tag Manager container present and configured, not an empty shell.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change.
Conversion tracking Conversion_Tracking 0.04	Lead events actually wired — form submit, call click, chat open — not just pageviews.	IDENTICAL	IDENTICAL	No change.
CRM integration CRM_Integration 0.02	Evidence of a CRM or lead-routing endpoint receiving submissions.	DATA VinSolutions, DealerSocket, Elead, HubSpot, Salesforce. Data typically stays onshore.	DATA Same global CRMs plus local dealer systems — Pentana, Titan DMS, EasyCars, AutoPlay . Most are US-hosted, making lead capture an APP 8 overseas disclosure .	Add AU DMS vendors to detection. Pair a detected US-hosted CRM in an AU audit with the Pillar 4 overseas-disclosure check — a cross-pillar finding nobody else reports.

Summary: sixteen changed parameters cluster into three groups — **provider dictionaries** (history, valuation, trust badges, credentials, CRM), **pricing and finance disclosure rules** (total price, comparison rate, credit licence, APR), and **consent rules** (opt-in vs opt-out for email and SMS). Only the second group needs new detection logic.

Implementation plan

You already store the visitor's market on the audit run, and `countries.js` says so explicitly: "nothing scores differently because of it yet". Here is the smallest change set that turns that stored value into real market-aware scoring.

Step 1 — Resolve the market once, at the top of the run

Do not trust the dropdown alone. Resolve strongest signal first and record which one won, so the report can explain itself:

- **ccTLD** — `.au` is near-conclusive. `citationConsistency.js` already does this.
- **Schema `addressCountry`** — already walked by `tuCollectLocationTerms`, including `AU-QLD` style codes.
- **State tokens and phone country code** — the AU detection in `citationConsistency.js` already matches sydney/melbourne/brisbane/NSW/VIC/QLD and friends. Promote it to a shared utility.
- **Currency and units on the page** — AUD, "drive away", L/100km, km.
- **User selection** from the audit form — authoritative when signals are silent, overridden when they clearly conflict.
- **hreflang / `html[lang]`** — weakest; frequently wrong on ported templates.

A conflict between signals is itself a sellable finding. An AU-market site publishing USD prices, MPG and a US state dropdown is running an unlocalised American template. That single insight justifies the audit.

Step 2 — One locale pack, not scattered conditionals

Asset	US contents	AU contents	Consumed by
Formats	NANP phone, 5-digit ZIP, 2-letter states, MM/DD/YYYY, USD, miles, MPG	+61 incl. 1300/1800/13, 4-digit postcode, 8 state codes, DD/MM/YYYY, AUD, km, L/100km	<code>Citation_NAP_Consistency</code> , <code>Click_To_Call</code> , <code>Content_Updated_Regularly</code> , <code>Inline_Validation</code> , schema checks
Gazetteer	Cities, states, metros, counties	Suburbs, capital cities, states, regions	<code>Title_Location_Optimization</code> , <code>Topical_Authority</code> , local landing-page checks
Vocabulary	MSRP, trunk, gas, tire, pre-owned, out-the-door	Drive-away, on-roads, boot, petrol, tyre, ute, rego, RWC, second-hand	<code>Content_Relevance</code> , <code>Terminology_Consistency</code> , <code>CTA_Clarity</code> , <code>FAQ_QA_Blocks</code>
Vehicle taxonomy	US makes / models / trims	HiLux, Ranger, D-MAX, Triton, LDV, GWM, MG, BYD; "variant"/"badge" not "trim"	<code>Keywords_Entities_Annotated</code> , <code>VDP_Content_Uniqueness</code> , <code>Inventory_Filtering</code>
Directories	Yelp, Cars.com, DealerRater, Edmunds, BBB	carsales, Autotrader.com.au, CarsGuide, Drive, ProductReview, Yellow Pages AU, True Local, ABN Lookup	<code>Social_Links</code> , <code>SameAs_Validation</code> , <code>Citation_NAP_Consistency</code> , <code>Reviews</code>

Asset	US contents	AU contents	Consumed by
Credentials	ASE, NADA, BBB, CARFAX, manufacturer CPO	Dealer licence no., ABN, AADA, VACC/MTA, RACV/NRMA/RACQ, PPSR	EEAT_Composite, Trust_Badges, Certifications_Awards
Data providers	CARFAX, AutoCheck, NMVTIS, KBB, Black Book	PPSR, CarHistory, RedBook, Glass's Guide	Vehicle_History, TradeIn_Flow
Authorities	NHTSA, EPA, IIHS, FTC, CFPB, ADA/Section 508, NIST	ANCAP, Green Vehicle Guide, ACCC, ASIC, OAIC, AHRC/DDA, ACSC	Citations_Attribution , every compliance finding's report copy

Step 3 — Market-specific parameters

New checks that apply in one market only. Keep them out of the shared denominator using the same not-applicable renormalisation you already use for page-type-specific parameters.

New parameter	US	AU	Basis	Why build it
Total / drive-away price prominence	—	Yes	ACL s48	Hard legal requirement, simple DOM check, actively enforced by the ACCC in automotive.
Comparison rate & warning	—	Yes	National Credit Code	Deterministic string check wherever a rate is advertised.
Australian Credit Licence number	—	Yes	NCCP Act 2009	Present or absent; no judgement required.
Dealer licence number in advertising	Varies by state	Yes	State motor dealer acts	Trust signal and compliance item; trivially detectable (LMCT, licence no.).
ABN present & consistent	—	Yes	Convention + ABN Lookup	Verifiable government identifier — real entity-grounding value for AEO.
Overseas disclosure in privacy policy	—	Yes	APP 1.3(f)	Almost universally missing; pairs with vendors you already detect.
Pre-ticked marketing consent	Permitted	Fails	Spam Act 2003	Clean opt-in vs opt-out divergence, easy to detect in the DOM.
PPSR / history check offered	CARFAX analogue	Yes	PPS Act 2009	Top AU used-buyer expectation; direct analogue of the CARFAX badge check.
"Do Not Sell or Share" link + GPC	Yes	—	CCPA / CPRA	The US mirror-image requirement. Must not run against AU sites.
APR on triggering terms	Yes	—	Reg Z 1026.24	The US analogue of the comparison-rate check.

New parameter	US	AU	Basis	Why build it
Locale contamination	Both	Both	Derived	US-only terms, units or currency on an AU site (or the reverse). Cheap, distinctive, immediately credible.
Origin / CDN geography	Informational	High value	Derived	Explains AU TTFB and LCP results that otherwise look inexplicable.

Step 4 — Keep scores comparable

Never change a global threshold to make a market look better. Core Web Vitals numbers, WCAG success criteria and OWASP header baselines stay fixed. Market awareness belongs in exactly three places: **which parameters apply**, **which reference list is compared against**, and **what the finding says**. Move a threshold instead and a US score stops meaning the same thing as an AU score — which is the product's main claim.

Build order

- **Phase 1 — formats.** Phone and address normalisers, postcode and state formats, date parsing. Fixes outright broken behaviour in `Citation_NAP_Consistency` and `Click_To_Call`. Highest impact, lowest effort.
- **Phase 2 — dictionaries.** Gazetteer, vocabulary, vehicle taxonomy, directories, credentials, providers. Fixes nine of the top twelve ranked changes.
- **Phase 3 — AU compliance parameters.** Total price, comparison rate, credit licence, dealer licence, overseas disclosure, pre-ticked consent. The commercially differentiating work.
- **Phase 4 — derived findings.** Locale contamination and origin/CDN geography. Distinctive insights no generic SEO tool produces.

The bodies of law and standards referenced throughout, so each finding cites the right authority for the market it was raised in.

Domain	United States	Australia	Global / shared
Privacy	CCPA / CPRA, CalOPPA, ~20 state comprehensive laws, GLBA, FCRA, DPPA, COPPA. Regulators: FTC, state AGs, CPPA.	Privacy Act 1988 (Cth) + 13 APPs; Notifiable Data Breaches scheme; Privacy and Other Legislation Amendment Act 2024. Regulator: OAIC.	GDPR / UK GDPR apply to a site in either market if it targets EU or UK visitors.
Consumer protection	FTC Act s5; FTC Used Car Rule (16 CFR 455); Rule on Consumer Reviews and Testimonials (16 CFR 465). <i>CARS Rule (16 CFR 463) vacated Jan 2025 — verify.</i>	Australian Consumer Law (Sch 2, CCA 2010): s18, s29, s48 single price, consumer guarantees. Regulators: ACCC and state fair-trading offices.	Both prohibit misleading pricing and fake reviews; the mechanics differ.
Consumer credit	TILA / Reg Z (12 CFR 1026), Consumer Leasing Act / Reg M, ECOA / Reg B. Regulators: CFPB, FTC.	NCCP Act 2009 + National Credit Code; comparison-rate and warning requirements; ASIC RG 234. Regulator: ASIC.	Both demand honest, complete cost-of-credit disclosure — expressed as APR vs comparison rate.
Motor dealer regulation	State dealer licensing and advertising rules; NMVTIS; state lemon laws; Monroney label (15 U.S.C. 1232).	NSW Motor Dealers and Repairers Act 2013; VIC Motor Car Traders Act 1986 (LMCT); QLD Motor Dealers and Chattel Auctioneers Act 2014 and equivalents. Statutory used-car warranty and cooling-off vary by state. PPSR under the PPS Act 2009.	Both are sub-national — never present either as one national rule set.
Accessibility	ADA Title III; Section 508 / Revised 508 Standards; DOJ Title II rule (2024) adopting WCAG 2.1 AA.	Disability Discrimination Act 1992; AHRC <i>World Wide Web Access</i> advisory notes; AS EN 301 549; Digital Service Standard.	W3C WCAG 2.1 / 2.2 Level AA is the shared technical standard.
Security	FTC Safeguards Rule (16 CFR 314); NIST SP 800-52 Rev 2; NIST CSF 2.0.	ACSC Information Security Manual; ACSC Essential Eight; APP 11 reasonable steps.	OWASP Top 10, OWASP Secure Headers, TLS 1.2+/1.3, HSTS — identical engineering baseline.
Marketing contact	CAN-SPAM (opt-out); TCPA (prior express written consent for automated marketing calls and texts).	Spam Act 2003 (opt-in, sender identification, unsubscribe within 5 business days); Do Not Call Register Act 2006.	The opt-in vs opt-out split is the single most consequential marketing-law difference.
Vehicle safety & environment	NHTSA recalls, IIHS crash ratings, EPA fuel economy and MPG label.	ANCAP crash ratings, Australian Design Rules, Green Vehicle Guide label (ADR 81/02), New Vehicle Efficiency Standard, Vehicle Recalls Australia.	No overlap at all — any authority whitelist must be market-specific.
Web & search standards	Shared and global: W3C HTML / ARIA / WCAG, schema.org, Google Search Central, Core Web Vitals thresholds, robots.txt (RFC 9309), IETF TLS.		This is why 72% of the parameters need no market logic at all.

Currency of information. This reflects the position as understood in mid-2026. Australian privacy reform and US state privacy and AI statutes are all moving. Treat the legal citations as a research starting point, confirm current status before publishing compliance assertions, and frame every finding as an observation about the page rather than a legal conclusion.